

projects with long-term commitments of their time without any monetary compensation whatsoever. A majority of the community thrives on the sheer goodwill that is generated by building and releasing really useful tools. It is the knowledge that there exists a portion of the world that implicitly thanks you for making their lives so much easier that actually drives some developers to make open source contributions.

Without people like Linus Torvalds and Richard Stallman, it is doubtful whether we would have ever gained enough advanced software-related prowess to claim that technology ‘can change the world’. Open source has been the backbone of all software-related progress; the easiest way to measure that is to note the times when GitHub went down, and then check what proportion of the tech universe could no longer continue with their daily workflow. I am willing to bet it’s more than half. That’s how important open source is in the tech field. Apart from the obvious personal benefits, it is worthwhile to contribute just as an appreciation of the efforts thousands of others are pouring into maintaining some semblance of transparency and goodwill in a world of tech titans that have recently been plagued by allegations of corruption, greed, negligence, monopolisation, abuse of power, and a failure of corporate governance.

Do companies actually care about open source?

Open source has been leveraged by companies in addition to individuals. To cite some examples, let us look at the recent corporate acquisitions. Long seen as a question mark, given the company’s non-committal responses on making its operating system open source, Microsoft saw the acquisition of GitHub as some sort of redemption, given its long-standing efforts to foster open source projects. In fact, GitHub has introduced the Windows Subsystem for Linux, leading to reduced overheads



Linus Torvalds (Linux, Git) with Richard Stallman (GNU) (source: Novemberain445)

for software developers building multi-platform tools.

Google and Facebook seem to be at the top of their game when it comes to making waves with releasing open source versions of their tools. Tensorflow, Pytorch, Android, Chromium, React.js, and React native, top rank among numerous other interesting and wildly popular internal tools that got open sourced after being polished for use. Apart from that, they come with a suite of tutorials, examples, documentation and a host of community building efforts including talks, live tutorials, and conferences. Individual contributions are largely what drive communities, but having a company support you often accelerates efforts and helps projects grow through their initial phase. More than that, it sets them up for long-term survival — knowing Google and Facebook are backing frameworks makes it extremely plausible that these companies will ensure their relevance in the future!

Getting back to the jobs perspective, given the abundance of opportunities, contributing to company-backed projects

may be a good way to attract some attention as a developer seeking a job. Of course, this is a long shot and would possibly require long periods of intense work reading the code base, reviewing changes, and eventually making a contribution. But it is not implausible given events like the ‘Summer of Code’ at which companies test applicants by assigning short timelines to complete them. This comes with additional mentoring for the specific projects by experts involved in them. It seems an ideal way to get started quickly — by making contributions. Most companies will look favourably at continuing those contributions and support your work should you make a strong case for it. Some go as far as to offer the role of a mentor for candidates that demonstrate enough expertise at the end of their stints. Sure, this works for summers of code, but in general, there is nothing stopping candidates from doing this at any point in the year. Most communities are happy to mentor newbies who exhibit the potential to turn into long-term contributors. So find an opening and take your shot. **END** 🐧

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